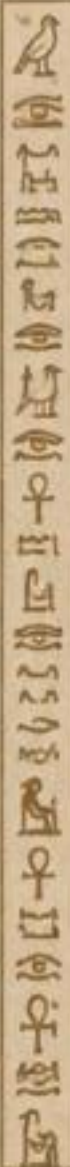




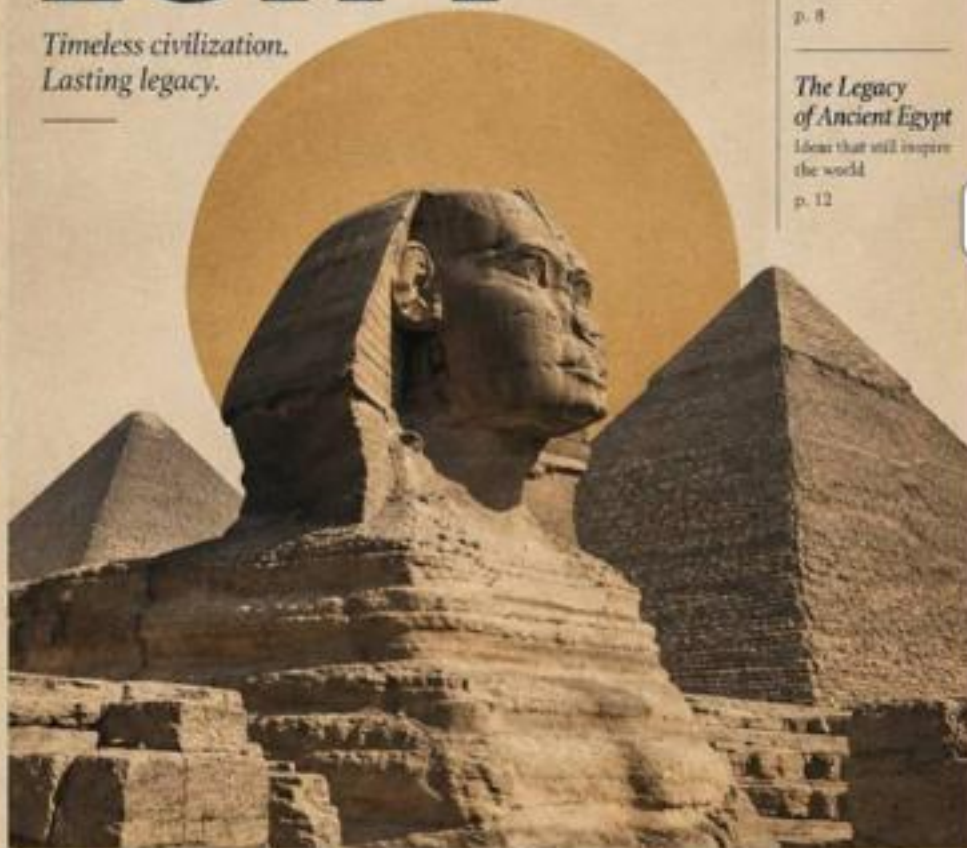
POLYCLOT



THIS MONTH'S THEME

ANCIENT EGYPT

*Timeless civilization.
Lasting legacy.*



The Pyramids of Giza

Engineering, mystery and eternal beauty
p. 4

Life Along the Nile

How the river shaped a civilization
p. 8

The Legacy of Ancient Egypt

Ideas that still inspire the world
p. 12

PAST / PRESENT / FUTURE



Who Owns the Pyramids?

For centuries, the pyramids of Egypt have fascinated historians, archaeologists, and amateur history buffs. We may know a great deal about who built them and why they were built, but a question we came up with is: Who actually owns the pyramids?

The answer is more complicated than it might seem. The simple answer is the country of Egypt. When we look at Egyptian law and some other sources, it does seem to be clear.





WHAT DOES EGYPTIAN LAW SAY?

According to the UNESCO Database of National Cultural Heritage Laws, Egypt's Law No.117 of 1983, as amended by Law No. 3 of 2010, provides the legal framework for protecting the country's antiquities.

Under Article 2, property of historical, scientific, religious, artistic, or literary value can be officially classified as an antiquity. Once classified, these sites receive special legal protection.

The law also defines archaeological buildings as buildings that were previously registered as archaeological sites or that have been registered under the provisions of the law.

Article 3 further establishes protections for state-owned land that has been designated as archaeological land. Although certain land may be removed from this classification by legally authorized authorities—for example, when required for public-service purposes—the archaeological heritage itself remains protected.

What Happens When an Antiquity Is Discovered?

Egyptian law also addresses what happens when someone discovers an archaeological site or object that has not previously been registered.

Article 23 states that anyone who discovers an unregistered immovable antiquity must notify the Supreme Council of Antiquities. The antiquity is then considered state property, and the Council is responsible for taking the necessary measures to protect it.

The government may either take possession of the antiquity, expropriate the land on which it was discovered, or allow the antiquity to remain where it was while officially registering and protecting it.

In certain circumstances, the person who reports the discovery may receive a reward determined by the appropriate government committee.

SO, WHO OWNS THE PYRAMIDS?

The Library of Congress explains that Egyptian law establishes a strong system of state ownership and protection for antiquities.

Under this legal framework, ancient monuments and archaeological sites—including the Giza pyramid complex—are generally considered state property. They cannot be treated like ordinary private real estate that an individual can buy, sell, or give away.

The principal legislation is Law No. 117 of 1983 on the Protection of Antiquities, together with subsequent amendments.

Egypt's Constitution also provides additional protection for the country's antiquities. It prohibits giving antiquities away as gifts or exchanging them, while attacks against or trafficking in antiquities are treated as serious crimes.



INSIDE THE GREAT PYRAMID

A PEELED-BACK VIEW OF THE PYRAMID'S INTERIOR



BUILT FOR PHARAOH KHEFUFU
c. 2580–2560 BCE

ORIGINAL HEIGHT:
146.6 m (481 ft)

BASE LENGTH:
230.4 m (756 ft)

ESTIMATED STONE BLOCKS:
~2.3 MILLION

LAYERS (OUTSIDE TO INSIDE)

-  1 Outer Casing Stones
Smooth Tura limestone
-  2 Inner Casing Stones
Fine limestone
-  3 Core Masonry
Rough limestone blocks
-  4 Interior Limestone
Fine (at blocks)
-  5 Granite (King's Chamber & elements)

OUTER CASING STONES

Smooth white Tura limestone gave the pyramid its brilliant, shining appearance.

CORE MASONRY

Massive, rough limestone blocks provide the bulk and strength of the pyramid.

QUEEN'S CHAMBER

Smaller chamber with a gabled (pointed) roof. Likely not used as a burial chamber.

SUBTERRANEAN CHAMBER

Carved into the natural bedrock beneath the pyramid. Its purpose remains a mystery. It is not connected to the pharaoh's burial chambers.



RELIEVING CHAMBERS

Five stepped chambers above the King's Chamber spread the weight of the pyramid.

GRAND GALLERY

A tall, sloping corridor with corbelled ceiling that leads down to the King's Chamber.

ASCENDING PASSAGE

Leads from the Grand Gallery up toward the entrance on the north face.

KING'S CHAMBER

Rectangular granite chamber that once housed the pharaoh's sarcophagus.

DESCENDING PASSAGE

Sloping passage that leads down from the entrance to the Subterranean Chamber.

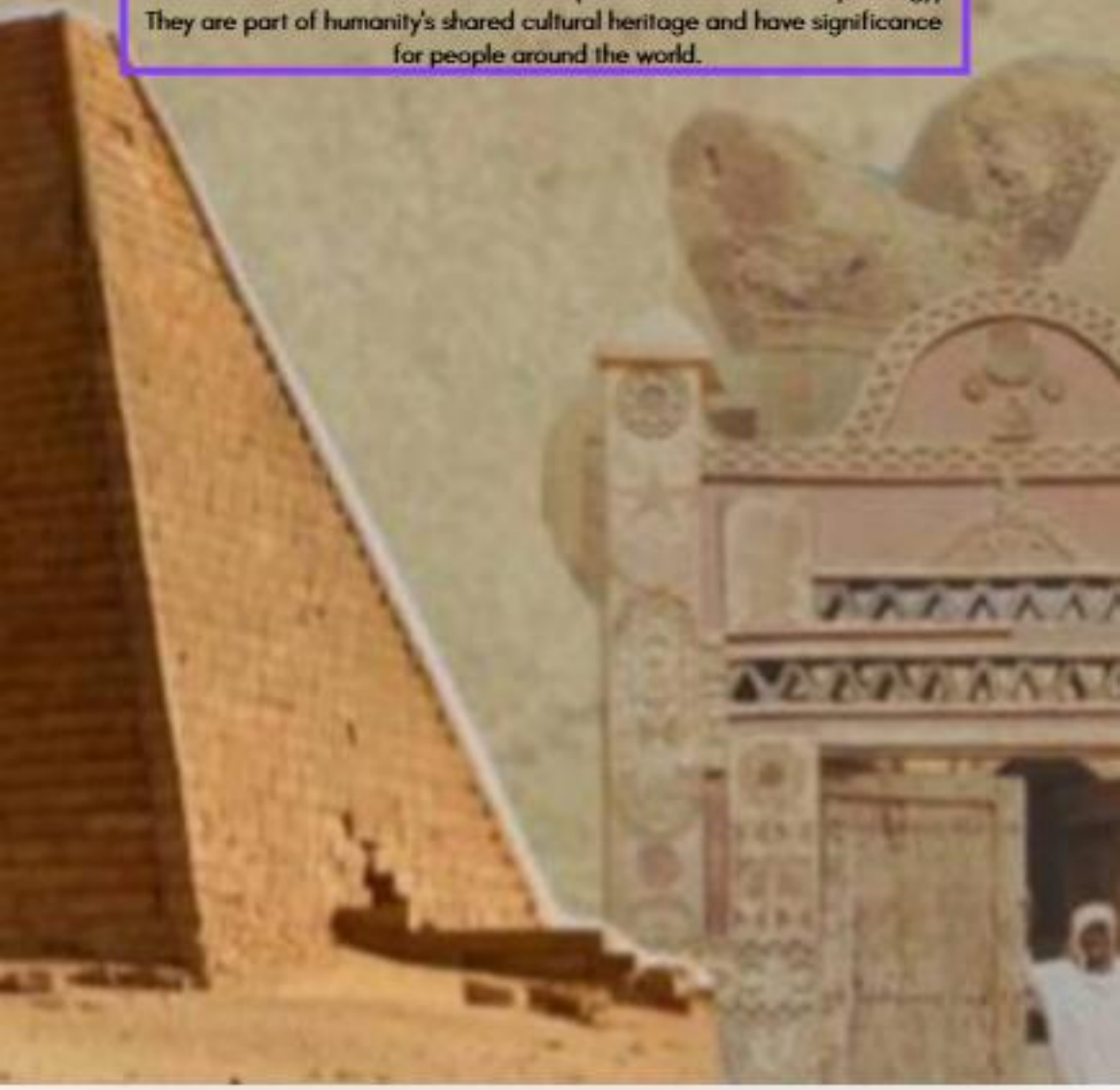
The Answer

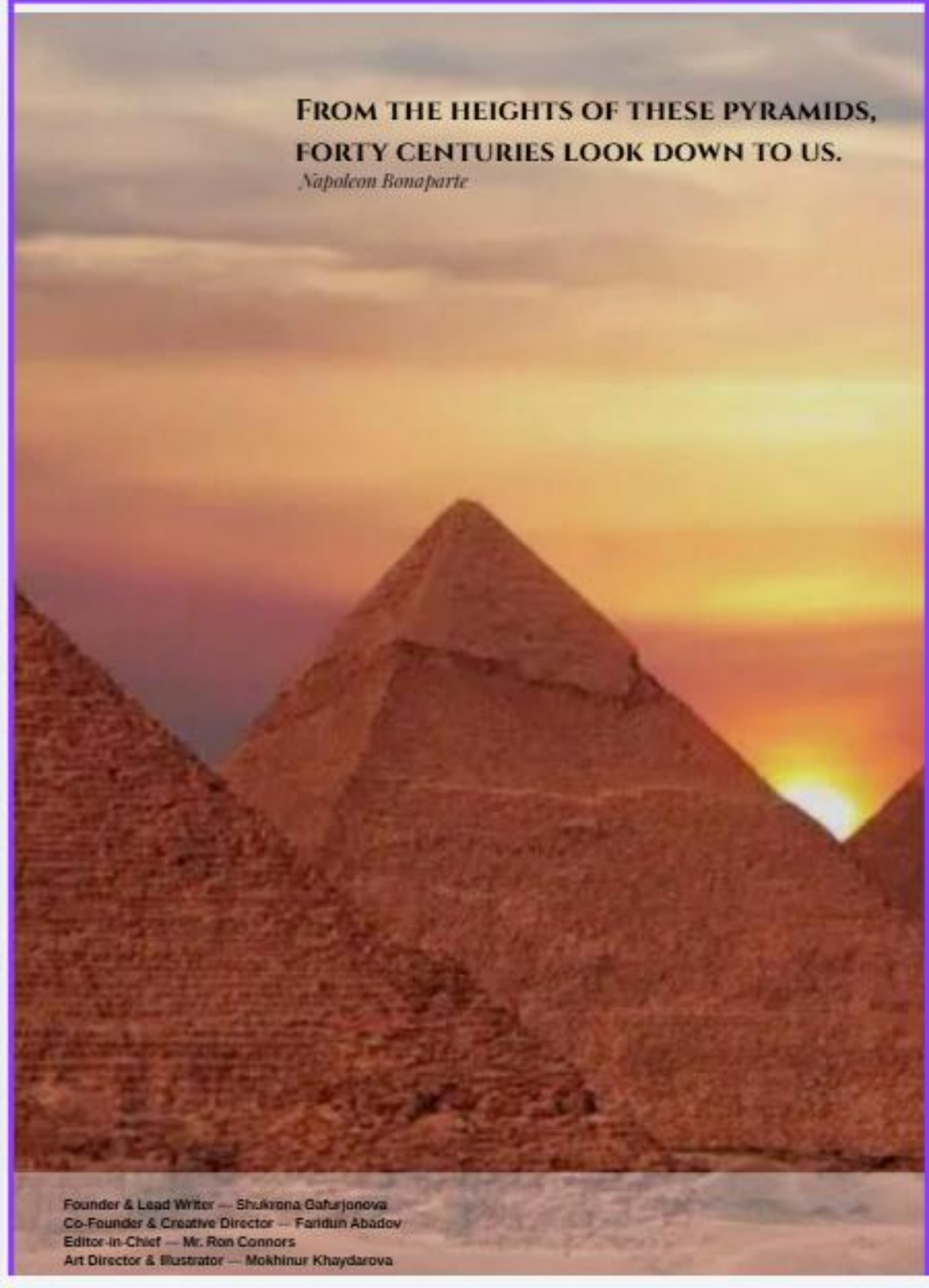
SO, WHO OWNS THE PYRAMIDS ?

Legally, Egypt does. The pyramids are part of Egypt's archaeological and cultural heritage and are protected under Egyptian law. They are not privately owned buildings that can be bought or sold.

But there is another way to look at the question.

The pyramids are located in Egypt and are protected by the Egyptian government. They are also a tremendous source of income, particularly from tourism but their historical and cultural importance extends far beyond Egypt. They are part of humanity's shared cultural heritage and have significance for people around the world.





**FROM THE HEIGHTS OF THESE PYRAMIDS,
FORTY CENTURIES LOOK DOWN TO US.**

Napoleon Bonaparte

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